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ACADEMIC VAULT

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GST 107: Nigerian Peoples and Culture - Diversity, History and Nation-Building

The context every Nigerian graduate should be able to explain without slogans

GST / COMPULSORY

GST & Compulsory Courses

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

This pack organises Nigeria's pre-colonial societies, cultural institutions, colonial experience and post-independence challenges into clear themes you can actually remember. It replaces vague 'unity in diversity' answers with specific examples, dates and arguments.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Describe the political and social organisation of at least three pre-colonial Nigerian societies.
- Explain how colonialism reshaped Nigerian economies, identities and boundaries.
- Distinguish cultural relativism from ethnocentrism with Nigerian examples.
- Discuss national integration using evidence rather than slogans.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Peoples, cultures and the danger of stereotypes

Nigeria has more than 250 ethnic groups and over 500 languages. The three largest - Hausa-Fulani, Yoruba and Igbo - are often used as shorthand, but that shorthand hides enormous internal diversity.

Culture includes language, religion, food, dress, marriage, music, craft, political organisation and shared values. It is learned and changes over time; it is not biological.

Ethnocentrism judges another culture by the standards of one's own. Cultural relativism tries to understand a practice within its own context - without pretending that every practice is beyond criticism.

- Hausa city-states and the Sokoto Caliphate: centralised emirate administration, Islamic scholarship and trans-Saharan trade.
- Yoruba kingdoms: Ife and Oyo, divine kingship, the Oyo cavalry and a rich oral and artistic tradition.
- Igbo societies: largely acephalous village republics, age grades, title societies such as Ozo, and the Nri ritual complex.

- Minority and riverine peoples: the Tiv, Ijaw, Efik, Ibibio, Nupe, Kanuri and many others with distinct political systems.

Pre-colonial trade, craft and knowledge

Long before colonial boundaries, the area that became Nigeria had sophisticated economies and knowledge systems.

- Trans-Saharan trade linked Kano and Katsina to North Africa through leather, salt, kola and horses.
- The trans-Atlantic slave trade devastated communities and created wealth for intermediaries; its consequences outlasted abolition.
- Benin bronzes, Ife terracotta heads, Nok figures and Igbo-Ukwu bronzes show advanced metallurgy and artistry.
- Palm oil production, fishing, weaving, blacksmithing and salt making supported regional trade.
- Indigenous medicine, astronomy and agriculture were systems of knowledge, not mere superstition.

Colonialism and its long shadow

Colonial rule lasted roughly six decades but reorganised almost everything: boundaries, administration, economy, education and identity.

The 1884-85 Berlin Conference set the framework for European partition. The Royal Niger Company and later the British colonial administration merged protectorates in 1914 into a single entity.

Colonial economies were built around extraction - palm produce, cocoa, groundnuts, tin and later oil - with infrastructure designed to move goods to ports rather than connect Nigerian communities.

Indirect rule deepened some ethnic identities and created new administrative divisions. Mission schools produced a new elite that later led nationalist movements.

> **Exam precision**
> Do not write that 'the British united Nigeria'. They amalgamated territories for administrative convenience. The consequences - uneven development and contested citizenship - are still with us.

Nationalism, independence and nation-building

Nationalist movements used newspapers, unions, market associations and political parties to demand self-government.

- Early nationalism: Herbert Macaulay and the NNDP; the Aba Women's War of 1929 against colonial taxation.
- Mass nationalism: Nnamdi Azikiwe, Obafemi Awolowo, Ahmadu Bello and the parties they led.
- Independence in 1960; a republic in 1963; civil war from 1967 to 1970.
- Military rule alternated with short democratic periods until civilian rule returned in 1999.
- Federal character, state creation and revenue allocation are responses to the challenge of governing diversity.